‘Well, there you are. Just get out there and be with her. That’s the best news anybody could ever have. Just think about that. It was a soccer match. This is a new life.’

When Seba Veron joined United, I remember we talked about the reaction of the Argentinian players, or at least some of them, when they saw me with my dad that night. As their coach pulled away out of the parking lot, we could see them looking back, bare-chested, laughing and swinging their shirts above their heads.

We went straight to the airport and then flew back to La Baule for our last night at France 98. Some of the players went right to their rooms; others went for a drink. I found myself in the games room with Terry and Slatts and Steve McManaman. Usually, we’d have hot chocolates and get off to bed a little after midnight. That last night, though, Terry told me I had to have something to drink. I had a couple of beers. I don’t usually drink but, that evening, the alcohol helped numb the pain a little. We hung around, the four of us, not saying all that much—there wasn’t much to say by now—and I don’t think I turned in until about four in the morning, even though we had to be up at nine for our Concorde flight back to England.

I made arrangements to travel to the States that same night. England were out of the World Cup. I wanted as much time with Victoria as possible before training for a new season started. My parents flew straight back to England from Saint-Etienne and were there to meet me at Heathrow the following day. By the time Concorde touched down, someone at the airport had been kind enough to offer us use of her office for the couple of hours before I got my connecting flight to the States. I found Mum and Dad, gave them my belongings and got changed for the onward flight. I knew I wouldn’t see them for the best part of a fortnight and I had news that I wanted to give them face to face rather than over a phone. I told them Victoria was pregnant.

They seemed very surprised. And worried, too. Maybe it was because they’d already got an idea of the reaction I was going to get back home after my sending off. Joanne was with them and she hugged and kissed me, but Mum was quite quiet and I remember Dad just said:

‘Are you sure it’s not too soon?’

We had to say our goodbyes. I headed off to the departure lounge and checked in my luggage without any fuss at all. I’d been warned that there would be press around looking for me but it seemed like everything was quiet. Once I was through security, I thought I’d be fine, that nobody would